

Chapter 124-4

Liang Shi was always smiling, standing out among those children who were trembling with fear.

Even though she was standing there holding a foam board, facing a terrifying threat to her life, her smile never stopped.

One kidnapper was so creeped out by her smile that he kicked her and told her to stop smiling.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, but a moment later she smiled again—just not as wide as before.

Even though her eyes were filled with tears, looking utterly pitiful.

That kidnapper said: "Is this one a fucking idiot?"

Another one said: "What a pity, she's quite pretty too."

Everyone assumed she was an idiot, but she had secretly told Xu Qingzhu: "Life is already hard enough, so we should smile more. As long as we smile more, life will get better."

She would talk to Xu Qingzhu, would comfort Xu Qingzhu in a low voice, would coax Xu Qingzhu not to cry, would pull out White Rabbit milk candies¹ from her own pocket to give to Xu Qingzhu.

She was like a little angel. Back then, Xu Qingzhu thought she was so amazing.

During the days they were held captive there, it wouldn't be an exaggeration to say they depended on each other for survival.

But it was also because the two of them interacted too frequently that they were pulled out by those hateful kidnappers to "play a game."

Their tastes were cruel and bloody. Just the moment she received the knife, Xu Qingzhu was so scared she wanted to cry. That beautiful little face was covered in tears as she timidly called out: "Jiejie..."

Xu Qingzhu's hands were trembling, and the knife slipped from her sweat-drenched hands. Meanwhile, Liang Shi, standing across from her, clearly knew something might happen to her, clearly had her legs shaking with fear, yet still smiled and said: "It's okay, don't be afraid."

As if she were the one holding the knife.

Xu Qingzhu was blindfolded with a cloth strip. Someone gripped her shoulders and guided her toward Liang Shi's direction.

That factory was quiet, damp, filled with the rustling sounds of rats, the disgusting smell of smoke and alcohol, the agonizing sounds of jeering laughter. Most crucially, there was the fear of the unknown.

That fear came from the possibility that she might kill someone, that she might use that knife to hurt someone she was very close to.

She called out in a trembling voice, again and again: "Jiejie... Jiejie..."

Those people laughed even louder. "What a touching display of sisterly love. Then go ahead and stab—let's see if you can stab your dear jiejie."

A knife was forcibly shoved into Xu Qingzhu's tender white little hands. She could feel the cold metallic texture, could even feel the sharpness of the blade—she could hear clearly the sound it made cutting through the air.

As if it could slice through the wind.

This was probably the suffering of having hearing that was too good.

Xu Qingzhu frowned as she moved forward. Her legs seemed to not belong to her anymore; she only knew to walk forward numbly. Her arms had curled back entirely, afraid of stabbing someone.

She tried to keep the knife pointed down as much as possible, but when those people noticed, they grabbed her by the hair.

That pain and humiliation of being bullied hit her in an instant. Even after so many years, she still couldn't forget it.

Back then, she was also blindfolded with cloth strips, unable to see anything, only able to move forward using her good hearing. She was afraid of becoming a murderer, afraid of hurting Liang Shi.

Tears soaked through the black cloth strip, revealing a faint glimmer of light.

Even when she was bullied, she didn't dare cry loudly. She could only bite her lip and sob quietly, because children who cried loudly here would get beaten.

The dilapidated, abandoned old factory was a living hell.

And the moment her hair was grabbed, Liang Shi threw down the foam board and went to hit that person. She was young and didn't have much strength, and having been hungry for so long, she was no match for that man at all. But she showed no fear. When hitting and kicking weren't enough, she used her teeth to bite. When she bit hard enough to make him hurt, he let go and slapped her across the face.

The pitiful little child was bullied there with no ability to resist.

That they could survive at all was a miracle.

After all the commotion, young Xu Qingzhu was blindfolded with the cloth strip again. Her world was pitch black. She called out in a trembling voice: "Jiejie..."

Liang Shi answered: "I'm here. Don't be afraid."

Liang Shi said: "Be a little braver. I'm fine."

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Her PTSD started from there.

There are many things that can trigger fear in post-traumatic stress disorder. She had already tried her best to control herself.

But if a condition could be controlled, it wouldn't be called a condition.

No patient would willingly choose to become a patient.

Footnotes:

¹ **White Rabbit milk candies (大白兔奶糖):** A famous Chinese candy brand that has been beloved by generations of Chinese children since the 1940s. These are soft, chewy milk-flavored candies wrapped in edible rice paper, often associated with childhood nostalgia and comfort in China.